



GOVERNANCE

CITIZEN'S PARTICIPATION

MODULE - 11

1. CIVIL SOCIETY

- 1** The term civil society refers to the wide array of **nongovernmental and not for-profit organizations** that have a presence in public life, expressing the interests and values of their members or others, based on ethical, cultural, political, scientific, religious or philanthropic considerations.
- 2** Civil Society Organizations (CSOs) therefore, refer to a wide of array of organizations: **community groups, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), labour unions, indigenous groups, charitable organizations, faith-based organizations, professional associations, and foundations**’.
- 3** Hegel was the first philosopher to separate civil society and the state, and this was followed by number of other scholars.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

FEATURES OF CIVIL SOCIETY

The following are the features of civil society:

- 1** It refers to an organized form of society.
- 2** It covers a large space in the society.
- 3** Even though it is an autonomous entity, it is still subject to control by the state.
- 4** It is in pursuit of common good of the people.
- 5** It helps in formulation of public opinion and sets-up demand which are general in nature.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

FEATURES OF CIVIL SOCIETY

- 6 It is an advocate of pluralism in order to reduce the domination of the state.
- 7 It is a non-state institution.
- 8 Its existence implies that there is freedom of expression, freedom of thought, and other fundamental rights of the people.
- 9 It is in opposition to authoritarianism and totalitarianism.
- 10 By educating the people, it promotes the citizenship.
- 11 It facilitates participation of the citizens in the administrative matters.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

COMPONENTS

The following organizations and groups are included under the ambit of civil society:

- a** Community-based organizations
- b** Cooperative societies
- c** Youth groups
- d** Farmers organizations
- e** Religious associations
- f** Trade unions
- g** Non-governmental organizations
- h** Indigenous people's organizations
- i** Women's groups
- j** Other similar organized groups in the society



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

COMPONENTS

1 In countries like the USA, the civil societies are well-established, while in developing countries like India, they are still underdeveloped.

2 It can be understood by the case in India that, here the civil society groups in opposition to the Government is well-developed, but civil society as an associational group representing interests of wide segments of the society is not fully functional yet.

3 In India, the civil society groups are apart from voluntary associations, seen as fluid associations of social groupings based on caste, kinship, religious ties, etc.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

ROLE

- 1** The civil society organizations play a very important role in welfare and development of the people in the society.
- 2** The various dimensions of their role are as follows:
 - a** They help in facilitation of people's participation in governance.
 - b** They help the administration by identifying the target groups.
 - c** They help to create political consciousness among the people by discussing various political issues with them.
 - d** They help to strengthen the principle of self-help.
 - e** They act as the watchdog of public interest.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

ROLE

f They make the administrative machinery more responsible and responsive to the needs and aspirations of the people.

g They mobilize and organize the poor for the purpose of socio-economic development.

h They help in identifying and using the local resources for the purpose of development and thereby make the communities self-reliant.

i They disseminate information and help to make people aware of the various schemes, programs, and activities, developed by the government for their welfare.

j They try to reduce the scope of corruption, by imposing a community system of accountability on the administration at lower levels.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

ROLE

3 The voluntary agencies also have other advantages over the governmental bodies. They are:

- a** They can have better rapport with the local people than that by the government officials.
- b** They can be very flexible, and act in such a manner as they are not bound by rigid bureaucratic rules, regulations and procedures.
- c** The volunteers involved are sincerer and more dedicated to the task of reducing the sufferings of the poor than the governmental staffs.
- d** They can motivate the public to participate more effectively than the governmental agencies.
- e** The efforts carried out by such agencies are more economical than that of the governmental bodies.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

LIMITATIONS

Though there are numerous advantages of the civil society, they do suffer from a number of limitations, which are as follows:

- a** Interference and involvement of the political parties.
- b** Lack of qualified and trained professionals.

- c** Presence of diverse socio-economic environment in the country, such as casteism, poverty, and communalism, etc.



1. CIVIL SOCIETY

LIMITATIONS

d Non-cooperation and even resistance by the bureaucrats.

e No holistic perspective, rather they have a limited narrow perspective.

f They do not have sufficient financial resources.

g They lack adequate and proper information base.

h The resistance offered by local landlords, moneylenders, etc.



2. PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION

1 People's participation in the governance is considered to be one of the most important aspects which is discussed throughout the developed world.

2 And India is no exception. People's involvement in governance is considered to be a significant variable for bringing accelerated socio-economic development with equitable, sustainable and inclusive development

3 People's participation is essential for development as it helps in breaking down, realigning and replacing economic, social and political structures that are considered antithetical to the development process



2. PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION

4 Number of research scholars, social scientists, academicians, various research institutions and voluntary organizations have expressed their concern regarding people's participation in the development process.

5 Also great visionaries such as Aristotle, Mahatma Gandhi, Vinoba Bhave, J. S. Mill, Tagore and Jayaprakash Narayan etc have called for large-scale people's participation in the developmental activities.

6 If there is this thinking that, everything will be done by the government and by the officials who are being paid for it, then the developmental plans or programmes will not give satisfactory or substantial results, success can only be achieved by involvement and participation of the people in the developmental process.



Aristotle



Mahatma
Gandhi



J. S. Mill

2. PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION

FACTORS DETERMINING PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION

According to Cohen and Uphoff, Uphoff, Norman Approaches, there are four important kinds of participation, which are:

- i** **Participation in decision-making:** It focuses on identifying problems, formulating alternatives, planning activities, allocating resources, etc.
- ii** **Participation in implementation:** The emphasis on carrying out activities, managing and operating programmes, partaking of services
- iii** **Participation for benefits:** Participation in economic, social, political, cultural or other benefits, individually or collectively.
- iv** **Participation in evaluation:** Participation in evaluation of the activity and its outcomes, which should give feedback into above all three types of participation.



2. PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION

BENEFITS OF PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION IN ADMINISTRATION

The benefits of people's participation in administration are as follows:

- 1 It helps in selection of project which is directly relevant to the people.
- 2 It acts as a safeguard against the abuse of authority of administration and thus, reduces the scope of corruption.
- 3 It helps in prevention of hijacking of the projects by the richer and powerful sections of the society, as there is involvement of all section, especially the poor and weaker section in the development process. Thus, it leads to equitable sharing and distribution of the benefits in the society.



2. PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION

FACTORS AFFECTING PEOPLE'S PARTICIPATION

However, there are **number of factors** which act as impediment for effective participation of the people in the administration. These are:

- i** Negative political involvement and interference
- ii** Improper administrative procedure
- iii** Lack of culture of participation
- iv** Aristocratic and mechanical bureaucracy
- v** Role played by the **middle men**
- vi** Time constraints, that is, **time-bound nature** of the activities
- vii** Unfavourable socio-economic environment like presence of communalism, casteism, regionalism, illiteracy and poverty, etc.
- viii** Presence of corruption and low **standards** of conduct in administration.



3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

- 1 Several voluntary organizations were started in the field of education, health, etc., in the early 19th and 20th centuries.
- 2 The NGOs role became prominent after the independence, especially after 1970s.
- 3 This can be attributed to the limited past success of the development policies pursued by the government.
- 4 Despite half a century of development efforts initiated by the government, the problems of poverty, hunger, malnutrition, unemployment, illiteracy, gender inequality still persist and continue to plague our society.
- 5 One of the important factors that limited the success of these programmes were the lack of participation and involvement of the people for whom these programmes were meant.



3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS AND NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANIZATIONS

VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

- 1 Voluntary organizations are opposite to business and trade associations.
- 2 They are essentially non-profit and non-partisan organizations.
- 3 They are generally independent of the government and are characterized by their social service motive rather than profit-making motives.



3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS AND NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANIZATIONS

VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

- 4 The fundamental spirit that drives the VOs is voluntarism and it develops from varied sources such as charity, welfare of the needy, love for humanity, etc.
- 5 These organizations are controlled by motivated and spirited private citizens and not by the state.



3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS AND NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANIZATIONS

NGOs

- 1** The term Non-Governmental Organization has received widespread recognition internationally.
- 2** The United Nations refers to NGO as any international organization not established by intergovernmental agreement including acceptance or appointment of members designated by governmental authorities, and such membership should not interfere with the organization's free expression of views.
- 3** NGOs are different from the organs of and from those established by the market forces.



3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS AND NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANIZATIONS

NGOs

4 They are therefore, formal organs which exist beyond the Government and market and they run on the voluntary contributions made by the members of the society.

5 In India, term NGO is used to refer to wide spectrum of organisations, which may be non-governmental, voluntary or non-voluntary, quasi or semi-governmental, formal or informal, partisan or non-partisan, non-profit or profit-oriented bodies, with a legal status and registered under special acts such as Companies Act, Societies Act.

6 To be eligible for funding purpose, such organizations should be a legal entity and thus, possess legal status.



S. NO.	VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATION	NON-GOVERNMENTAL ORGANIZATION
1	Appointment of the staff is carried out by the governing board.	It is generally made by the members.
2	Salary is also determined by the governing board.	Salary is determined by the members.
3	Initiated and governed by its own board of members.	Initiated and governed by the interested people which can also be the government.
4	Funded mainly by agencies outside the government.	Receives funding from both external agencies and the Government
5	They do not have affiliation of the trade union unionized nor the political parties.	They can be unionized and politicised outside the sphere of the Government.

3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

FUNCTIONS OF THE VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

- 1** The voluntary agencies are in search to identify new or unmet needs and help achieve them through their own innovative methods.
- 2** They create public opinion and if required, get the state to act.
- 3** They can play meaningful role in three ways:
 - i** Build models, experiment with new and innovative programmes.
 - ii** Represent the rural local population by identifying with their needs and requirements.
 - iii** To catalyse the rural population towards the developmental approach.



3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

FUNCTIONS OF THE VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

4 The following are some of the areas where the VOs played important role:

- i Striving for the betterment and welfare of the Harijan families, and help to stop their exploitation and humiliation
- ii Spearheading anti-dowry campaign.
- iii Rehabilitation of bonded labourers.
- iv Arranging proper wages and ending exploitation of the bonded labourers, etc.



3. VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

SHORTCOMINGS OF THE VOLUNTARY ORGANIZATIONS

- 1 They do not get proper support neither from the bureaucracy nor from other local leaders.
- 2 Lack of inadequate funds.
- 3 Lack of professionalism, the VOs lack trained manpower to work in specific sectors and specialized areas.
- 4 The VOs which are dominated by charismatic leaders tend to decline when such leaders leave the organization.
- 5 They face organized opposition from the rich and powerful. This generally happens with the urban and rural elite who consider the VOs pose threat to their position of power.



4. NGOS AND WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

1 The participation of women in NGOs have given them an opportunity to enter into the social and political spheres which were not easily available for them in the public or even in the government.

2 Many of the NGOs that are working to alleviate poverty among the women also focus on upholding women rights.

3 These measures have brought significant changes in the life of the women.

4 NGOs also play a vital role in enforcement of the rights of the women as provided by the legislations and upheld in the Constitution of India.



4. NGOS AND WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

EMPOWERING WOMEN

1 The Women Self-Help Groups (SHGs) have been now recognized as an effective strategy for empowerment of women, especially in the rural areas as they strive to bring together women from all walks of life to create a livelihood for them.

2 SHGs also work on other variety of issues such as health, agriculture, forestry, nutrition, income generation activities, seeking of microcredit, etc.



4. NGOS AND WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

EMPOWERING WOMEN

3 The overall empowerment of women is fundamentally dependent on economic empowerment. Therefore, NGOs are involved in the following activities to empower women:

- i** Supplement the effort taken by the government for the empowerment of women.
- ii** Help to mobilize optimum resources for planning and implementing projects that have impact on women empowerment



4. NGOS AND WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

EMPOWERING WOMEN

iii Represent and articulate the problems faced by the rural women to the concerned officials and carry out social impact assessment of the policies that affect women.

iv Educate and create cognizance among women, especially rural women.

v Promote the use of the Information and Communication Technology (ICT) for empowerment of women.

vi Instil and develop leadership qualities among women and ensure that they participate in their empowerment process.



4. NGOS AND WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

WAY FORWARD

- 1** Despite the efforts made by the NGOs the ground reality not that encouraging as many women are **not yet empowered fully** and do not have any power or freedom to take decisions on their own.
- 2** Still a **lot more needs to be done**. NGOs can only supplement the efforts made by the government, and hence the **efforts of the government should be maximum**.
- 3** The Government should therefore, support the efforts taken by the NGOs.
- 4** The Government should **provide resources such as training facilities** and other mentoring services which help in the sustenance of the NGOs.



4. NGOS AND WOMEN EMPOWERMENT

WAY FORWARD

- 5 Establishment of more NGOs will help in the cause of empowerment of women.
- 6 Overall the NGOs have played significant role in bringing drastic changes in the life of women.
- 7 They are successful in making the women independent and self-reliant and help them to take decisions on their own.
- 8 They have also contributed in raising the literacy level and health of women.



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